

# MZ2POL-01: Introduction - Why Migrate from Management Zones

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Series: MZ2POL | Notebook: 2 of 8 | Created: December 2025

## Overview

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This notebook introduces the migration from **Management Zones (MZs)** in classic Dynatrace to the modern **Policies, Boundaries, and Segments** framework. Understanding why this migration is necessary and what benefits it brings is essential for planning a successful transition.

## Target Audience

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- Dynatrace administrators managing access control
- Platform engineers responsible for multi-tenant configurations
- Security teams overseeing data access policies
- Teams currently using Management Zones for data filtering

## Learning Objectives

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By the end of this notebook, you will:

1. Understand why Management Zones are being deprecated
  2. Know the key differences between MZs and the new model
  3. Recognize the benefits of Policies, Boundaries, and Segments
  4. Identify your current MZ usage patterns for migration planning
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# 1. The Evolution of Access Control in Dynatrace

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## What Are Management Zones?

Management Zones have been the primary mechanism for:

- **Data filtering**: Limiting what data users see in the UI
- **Access control**: Restricting user access to specific entities
- **Multi-tenancy**: Separating data for different teams, regions, or business units

## Why the Change?

Management Zones were designed for **classic Dynatrace** and have fundamental limitations:

| Limitation                | Impact                                          |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Precalculated attributes  | Performance bottleneck at scale                 |
| Not compatible with Grail | Cannot filter Grail-stored data                 |
| Limited flexibility       | Complex multi-dimensional filtering difficult   |
| Tight coupling            | Mixing "what" and "where" in a single construct |

## The New Platform Architecture

The latest Dynatrace platform uses **Grail** as its data lakehouse. Grail:

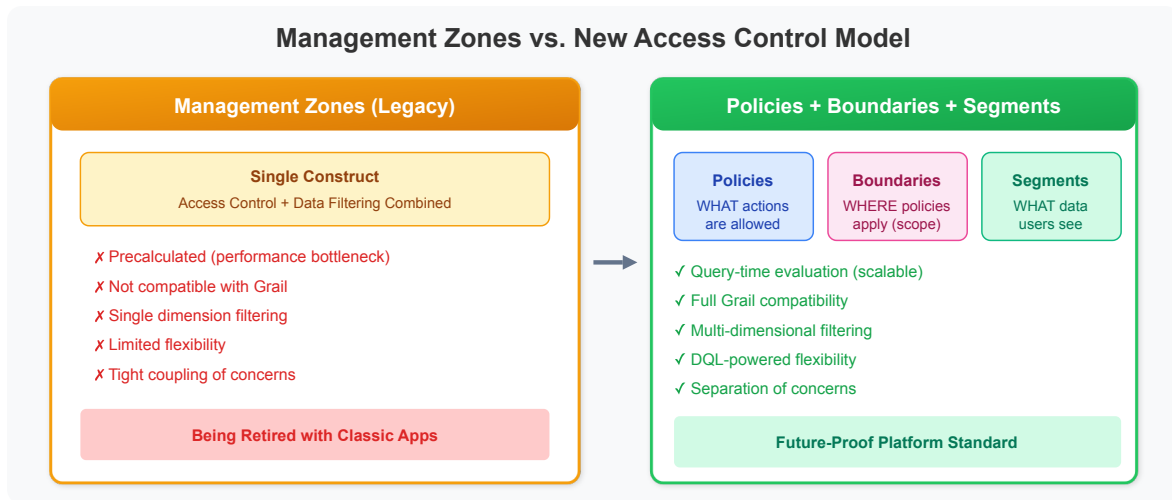
- Does **NOT** support Management Zones
- Uses **storage** fields for record-level access control
- Requires **IAM policies** for data access
- Leverages **Segments** for query-time filtering

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## 2. The New Access Control Model

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The modern Dynatrace access control framework is based on **ABAC (Attribute-Based Access Control)** and consists of three key components:



## Policies

**What they do:** Define WHAT actions users can perform

- Encapsulate permissions against protected platform resources and data
- Leverage user, resource, data, and contextual attributes
- Can be default (read-only) or custom

## Boundaries

**What they do:** Define WHERE policies apply (scope restrictions)

- Bundle restrictions on record and/or resource level
- Enable re-usability across multiple policy assignments
- Decouple "what" from "where" for easier management
- Used together with policies when assigning to groups

## Segments

**What they do:** Provide dynamic data filtering at query time

- Reusable, pre-defined filter conditions using DQL
- Support variables for dynamic filtering
- Multi-dimensional - can be layered for precise filtering
- Replace MZ filtering for cross-app data segmentation

## Comparison: Management Zones vs. New Model

| Aspect         | Management Zones           | Policies + Boundaries + Segments |
|----------------|----------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Scope          | Classic apps only          | All apps including Grail-based   |
| Performance    | Precalculated (bottleneck) | Query-time evaluation (scalable) |
| Flexibility    | Single dimension           | Multi-dimensional                |
| Reusability    | Limited                    | High (components are decoupled)  |
| Data filtering | Built into MZ              | Segments (separate concern)      |
| Access control | Built into MZ              | Policies + Boundaries (separate) |

## 3. Understanding Your Current Management Zone Usage

Before migrating, audit your current MZ implementation.

**⚠ Important:** Management Zone configurations **cannot be queried via DQL**.

**Options for viewing MZ configurations:**

1. **Dynatrace UI (Recommended):** Settings → Management Zones
2. **SDK Analysis:** See **MZ2POL-00: SDK Management Zone Analysis Tool** for comprehensive analysis including rule patterns, coverage metrics, and migration readiness.

## Check Entity Distribution by Management Zone

You can query entity distribution across MZs using DQL:

```
// Count entities per Management Zone
// Helps understand data distribution for Segment planning
fetch dt.entity.service
| expand mz = managementZones
| summarize serviceCount = count(), by:{managementZone = mz}
| sort serviceCount desc
| limit 20
```

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## 4. Benefits of Migration

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### Scalability

- **Query-time filtering** instead of precalculated attributes
- Handle orders of magnitude higher data volumes
- No performance degradation with complex filtering

### Flexibility

- **Multi-dimensional segments** - layer multiple filters
- **Dynamic variables** - adapt to user context
- **DQL-powered** - full query language for conditions

### Separation of Concerns

- **Policies:** What can be done (permissions)
- **Boundaries:** Where it can be done (scope)
- **Segments:** What data to show (filtering)

### Future-Proof

- Management Zones will be **retired** with classic apps
  - All new Dynatrace apps use Grail and Segments
  - Alerting profiles will be bound to Segments
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## 5. Migration Timeline Considerations

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### Current State (2025)

- Management Zones **still work** for classic apps
- New apps (Dashboards, Services app, etc.) require Segments
- Hybrid approach possible during transition

### What to Migrate

| Current MZ Use Case     | New Solution          |
|-------------------------|-----------------------|
| User access restriction | Policies + Boundaries |
| Data filtering in UI    | Segments              |
| Alerting profiles       | Segments (upcoming)   |
| Dashboard filtering     | Segments              |
| API access control      | Policies + Boundaries |

### Migration Phases

1. **Assessment:** Audit current MZ usage (this notebook)
2. **Planning:** Map MZs to Policies/Boundaries/Segments
3. **Implementation:** Create new access control constructs
4. **Validation:** Test access and filtering
5. **Cutover:** Transition users to new model
6. **Cleanup:** Remove deprecated MZ configurations

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## Summary

In this notebook, you learned:

1. **Why migrate:** Management Zones don't work with Grail and will be retired
2. **The new model:** Policies (what) + Boundaries (where) + Segments (filter)

3. **Key benefits:** Scalability, flexibility, separation of concerns
4. **Assessment queries:** How to audit your current MZ usage

## Next Steps

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Continue to **MZ2POL-02: Understanding the New Access Control Model** to dive deeper into:

- Policy structure and syntax
- Boundary configuration
- Segment creation and management

## Additional Resources

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- [Access Management Concepts](#)
  - [Policy Boundaries](#)
  - [Upgrade from RBAC to ABAC](#)
  - [Segments Documentation](#)
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